in the zone of cooperation was reached with secretary of state John Hay's "Open Door" policy of 1899, seeking to mitigate the effect of European spheres of influence in China in limiting trading access, and with American participation in allied military operations in China in the summer of 1901 during the Boxer Rebellion.[15]

America's zones in the Pacific emerged due to geopolitical, economic, and cultural pressures. The growth of the country's whaling fleet in the Pacific Ocean in the middle of the nineteenth century led to general arguments for a stronger US military presence in the region, eventually becoming the main impetus for Commodore Matthew Perry's famous mission to "open" Japan in 1853–54. Yet for decades, US trade in Asia lagged other regions and grew only slowly, with imports from Asia far outpacing exports. In 1840, five years after the establishment of the East India Squadron, trade with Asia amounted to just over $12 million, 90 percent of which involved imports to the United States.[16] On the eve of the Spanish-American War in 1897, US exports to Asia were still under $40 million, while nearly $92 million worth of goods were imported. Yet politics and other interests were at least as important as actual profits. Trade treaties during the mid-1800s with China (1844 and 1858), Japan (1858), and Siam (now Thailand) (1837), combined with an expatriate community of American Christian missionaries throughout the Pacific, mandated at least a modest US force in the region. Such forces were needed to protect both merchant rights and the lives of American citizens and consular officials, as attacks on American shipping in waters around far-flung Sumatra and Japan and violence against American diplomatic residences in Japan in the early 1860s proved.

American strategy, however, lagged commerce and religion, and emerged only fitfully in relation to the Pacific. During the 1860s, William Henry Seward, Abraham Lincoln's secretary of state, held perhaps the most articulated concept of US strategy in the region. Seward, echoing former president and secretary of state John Quincy Adams, argued that domination of global commerce was America's destiny, and that the Pacific would serve as a great highway to the riches of Asian markets.